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THE SANGH PARIVAR AND EDUCATION

Tribal Communities, Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram and Christian Missionaries

The holy fire in the Vedic altar rose up in flames, the smell of incense was everywhere and Sanskrit shlokas rent the air as the former prince sat on his haunches and washed the feet of a poor Adivasi in a large copper plate. There were over a hundred of them sitting in long queues, and one by one the prince cleaned their feet, welcoming them 'back' into the Hindu fold as the priests chanted in the background.

It was October 2003. The new tribal-majority state of Chhattisgarh was about to conduct its first-ever state assembly election[1] and I was following the campaign of the BJP's chief ministerial face, Dilip Singh Judeo. The moustachioed, swashbuckling scion of the royal family of Jashpur, who was fond of driving around in all-terrain jeeps, Judeo was a minister in Vajpayee's BJP-led government and a Rajya Sabha MP.[2] Presiding over such 'reconversion' ceremonies of tribals who had converted to Christianity had become a hallmark of his regional political imagery.

When journalist Sanjeev Singh and I met him on the election trail, he insisted that we come along to witness a ceremony deep in a tribal area of the state. He called it 'shuddhi' (purification),[3] and